

FOR FAMILIES OF THE GULF

# The Gulf Family's Guide to *South Africa.*

Nine hours from Dubai. A two-hour time difference. The Big Five without malaria tablets, and villas that belong only to your family. Everything we tell our own guests before they travel — written down, honestly.

# Why we wrote *this down*.

Every season, a small number of families from Dubai, Riyadh, Jeddah and Doha ask us the same first questions. How far is it, really? Is it safe for the children? Do we need injections? When should we go — and what does a journey like this honestly cost?

The answers are good news, almost without exception. South Africa is the closest “far away” the Gulf has: a place that feels like another world yet keeps your family on its own clock, with no vaccinations required, entire reserves free of malaria, and houses where the only other guests at dinner are the people you brought with you.

But that good news is usually buried under brochure language, and brochure language is designed to sell rather than to inform. So we have written the plain version — the one we give our own guests across the table in our Dubai office. Five short chapters. No stock phrases, and nothing we would not say to your face.

## HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Read it in twenty minutes with coffee. If it raises a question, our Dubai office answers on WhatsApp at **+971 58 858 5960** — a named person, not a call centre — or by email at **Lloyd@amarafrika.com**. There is no mailing list behind this document. One guide, and then silence, unless you write to us.

Chapter 01

# The two-hour *secret*.

The single most underrated fact about South Africa is where it sits on the map: almost directly south of the Gulf. You fly a long way — but you barely change time zones. Cape Town and Johannesburg run just two hours behind Dubai, and one hour behind Riyadh and Doha.

This changes everything about travelling with children. There is no jet lag to manage in either direction. Nobody is awake at 3 a.m.; nobody sleeps through the first game drive. Your family lands on essentially its own clock, and comes home the same way — back at school and at the office the next morning, intact.

## *The flights, plainly*

| ROUTE                                  | AIRLINE                             | TIME IN THE AIR                                                                           |
|----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Dubai → Cape Town</i>               | Emirates, daily, non-stop           | About 9¾ hours — overnight, so the family sleeps and wakes on approach over the Atlantic. |
| <i>Dubai → Johannesburg</i>            | Emirates, multiple daily            | About 8¾ hours — the gateway for safari in the north and east.                            |
| <i>Jeddah / Riyadh → Johannesburg</i>  | Via Dubai or Doha; seasonal directs | Comfortably done in a day, with connections timed for families.                           |
| <i>Doha → Cape Town / Johannesburg</i> | Qatar Airways, daily                | Non-stop on both routes.                                                                  |

Within South Africa, light aircraft and private charters connect city to reserve in under two hours. We hold the whole chain — international, domestic, road transfer — in one file, under one name.

WORTH KNOWING

No vaccinations are required for South Africa, and UAE, Saudi, Qatari, Kuwaiti, Bahraini and Omani passport holders travel with straightforward entry requirements. We confirm the current position for your passports as part of any design — you will never have to research it yourself.

## Chapter 02

# Big Five, *malaria-free*.

The question every parent asks first, and rightly: is it safe? Here is the answer most brochures blur, given straight. South Africa has entire world-class safari regions that are **completely malaria-free** — no tablets, no precautions, no compromise on the animals. Lion, leopard, elephant, rhino and buffalo, with nothing to take beforehand and nothing to worry about after.

### *The malaria-free reserves we use*

| REGION                       | CHARACTER                                                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Eastern Cape reserves</i> | Big Five reserves within reach of the Garden Route — ideal for combining safari with the Cape in one journey. Superb for first safaris with younger children. |
| <i>Madikwe Game Reserve</i>  | A large, quiet reserve on the Botswana border, closed to day visitors — only lodge guests may enter. Famous for wild dog and big elephant herds.              |
| <i>The Waterberg</i>         | Mountain wilderness a few hours north of Johannesburg — open country, few vehicles, and some of the country's finest exclusive-use villas.                    |

And the honest counterpart: the greater Kruger and its famous private reserves — the Sabi Sand among them — are *low-risk* rather than malaria-free, with simple seasonal precautions advised. For many families, particularly with older children, that trade is happily made for the density of game. For families with young children, or for complete peace of mind, we simply design around the malaria-free regions — and give up nothing that matters.

#### OUR POSITION

We will always tell you which category a lodge falls into before you decide — not after. If a journey can be designed malaria-free without losing what your family wants from it, that is the journey we will recommend.

## Chapter 03

# Lodges that belong *to you.*

The finest thing money buys on safari is not a suite. It is the whole house. South Africa leads the world in **exclusive-use villas** — private homes inside the great reserves, taken in their entirety by one family, with no other guests on the property at all.

What that means, practically: your own chef, cooking to your table's requirements — halal-aware dining briefed before you arrive, quietly and without further discussion. Your own safari vehicle and your own private guide, so the day runs on your family's hours: dawn drives for the early risers, a slow breakfast for everyone else, and nobody else's schedule to consider. Your own pool, your own staff, and privacy that is not a request but the architecture itself.

### *What the household gets*

Grandparents travel well here — distances inside the villa are short, the pace is yours, and there is always a veranda and a pot of tea between activities. Children are not merely tolerated but planned for: junior rangers' programmes, tracking lessons, their own early dinner if the adults wish to dine late. Staff and security travelling with the family are accommodated comfortably and discreetly — tell us the shape of the household and we design for all of it.

#### THE QUIET LUXURY

In an exclusive-use villa, no one photographs your family at breakfast. No strangers share the vehicle. For many of our Gulf guests, this — more than any thread count — is the definition of luxury: the wilderness of Africa, with the privacy of home.

## Chapter 04

# The seasons, *honestly*.

South Africa's seasons are the mirror of the Gulf's — and that mirror is your best friend. When Dubai and Riyadh are at their fiercest, South Africa is cool, dry and at its very best for safari.

## *The year, month by month*

| MONTHS                  | WHAT WE WOULD TELL YOU                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>May – October</i>    | The dry winter: the finest game-viewing of the year. Bush is thin, water is scarce, animals gather where you can see them. Days are warm, mornings crisp. <b>July and August — the Gulf summer holidays — land exactly in this window.</b> |
| <i>November – March</i> | Cape Town's season: warm, blue and glorious — beaches, vineyards, the mountain. Safari is greener and busier with newborn animals, with afternoon rains in the north. Ramadan and Eid dates are planned around with care.                  |
| <i>June – November</i>  | Southern right whales calve along the Cape coast — watched from the cliffs, no boat required. A quiet marvel for children.                                                                                                                 |
| <i>April &amp; May</i>  | The undervalued shoulder: golden light, thinner crowds, gentle rates. Some of our favourite journeys travel here.                                                                                                                          |

The honest caveat: the best villas in the best weeks are reserved six to twelve months ahead by families who travel every year. If you are thinking about July, the conversation should happen before the spring.

### THE GULF FAMILY'S SWEET SPOT

Escape the Gulf's hottest weeks into South Africa's finest safari season, on your own time zone, malaria-free if you wish. Few journeys on earth line up this conveniently — which is why the families who discover it tend to return every year.

# What your dirham *actually* buys.

Pricing is where most travel companies go vague. We would rather be plain. A private South African journey is not cheap — and at its best it is one of the most honestly valuable things luxury travel offers, because so much of what you pay for is exclusivity itself.

## The honest bands

| LEVEL             | WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE                                                                                                                     | GUIDE, PER PERSON                              |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Considered</i> | Top suites at leading lodges, private vehicle on safari, the Cape’s finest hotels, all ground arrangements. A superb first journey.    | From about USD 1,000–1,500 per night           |
| <i>Exclusive</i>  | Exclusive-use villas throughout — own chef, own guide, own vehicle. The private-house journey this guide describes.                    | From about USD 2,000–3,500 per night           |
| <i>Flagship</i>   | The rarest houses, private air throughout, a dedicated concierge travelling with the file. Ten to fourteen days, designed to the hour. | Typically USD 20,000–30,000+ per guest, all-in |

International flights are quoted separately, in the cabin you prefer. Every quotation we issue is itemised — you will see what each night and each flight costs, because a house that is vague about money is vague about other things too.

### HOW WE WORK

One senior designer holds your file from first call to final goodbye. Halal-aware dining is briefed to every property in advance. Arabic-speaking hosts and guides are arranged on request and when available. And we design for the whole household — grandparents, children, staff and security — because that is what a family journey actually is.

WHEN YOU ARE READY

# One conversation is worth five chapters — *so have it with a person.*

If South Africa has moved from idea to intention, the next step is simple: a conversation with a senior designer in our Dubai office. Tell us the shape of your family, the weeks you have, and the pace you keep — and we will tell you, honestly, what we would design and what it would cost. No call centre. No automated follow-up. One expert, by name.

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*WhatsApp · Dubai* +971 58 858 5960 — a named consultant replies

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*Email* Lloyd@amarafrica.com

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*The website* amarafrica.com — the journeys, the houses, the way we work

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